

Final Report

Department of Mechanical Engineering

University of Victoria

MECH 400B Capstone Design



Final Report

MECH 400B

Low Cost Smart Buoy

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April 21st, 2026

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1. Introduction and Overview

The low-cost smart surf buoy is an innovative solution to provide real-time ocean data for surfing and marine research. This project addresses the need for near shore localized maritime data at a lower cost than commercially offered solutions. The product will deliver wave height, wind speed, wind direction, water and air temperature, as well as wave period. The Buoy is engineered to be a durable autonomous and precise device that is easily deployable. The goal of the project is to manufacture, assemble and deploy a functional buoy on the West coast of Vancouver Island. The project objective is to design and build the buoy for a total cost less than a thousand dollars.

A final buoy design was found using a multitude of analytical tools. An in depth solar study was used to guide energy production decisions as well as placement on the buoy. Hull stability was calculated and improved upon by simulating the buoy in ProteusDS. This software was used to simulate the buoy during worst case waves and current situations. This was used to verify the use of a lazy S mooring system. All of these results were used to create the final prototype which was constructed. A fully functional prototype was wired, coded, and successfully deployed in the ocean.

2. Design Description

The low cost smart weather buoy is designed as an integrated system comprising 3 subsystems: mechanical, electrical, and software. The mechanical system encapsulates the hull form, mooring system, wind testing assembly, and the mounting frame for the electronics. The electrical system comprises the solar panels, battery and charging circuit as well as the sensors and controller. The software was used to collect the needed data followed by an in depth data processing pipeline. The complete buoy can be seen in Figure 1.

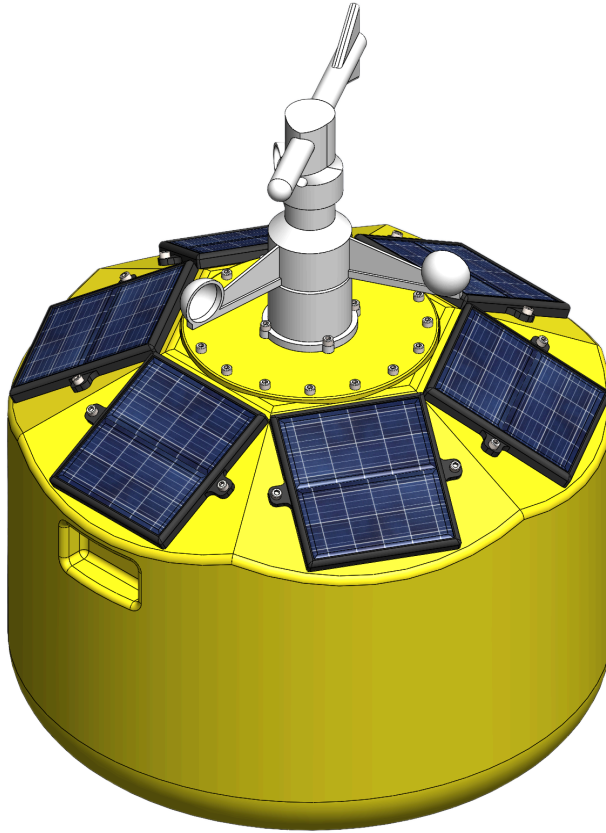


Figure 1: Buoy Complete Design

The hull is made from 34 separate 3D-printed pieces, which were glued together to create a durable hull structure. This was then epoxied, painted, and epoxied again to create a durable waterproof coating. The same process was completed on the buoy access panel. The 3D print pieces can be seen in Figure 2.

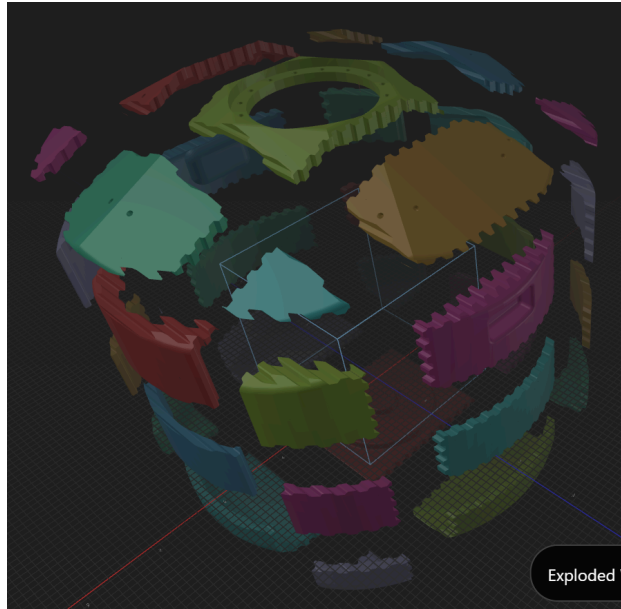


Figure 2: Buoy 3D Print Parts

The mooring system uses a S-curve design which was optimised in the Proteus software. The mooring line was connected to a permanently set hook in the bottom of the buoy hull. Having a mooring system that accounts for tide change is crucial for a buoy that is near shore. By creating a spring-like reaction to the buoy getting pulled by a wave the buoy maintains a smaller watch circle. The wind testing assembly has 5 separate 3D printed parts using delrin bushings to create a sea-proof smooth motion on a stainless steel rod. The wind sensor assembly is flange mounted to the access panel of the buoy. The buoy internals are housed in a tower configuration featuring a stack of battery, charge controller, and electronics mount. In the bottom of the buoy are sand compartments used to weigh down the buoy and remove high frequency noise from the data captured. This internal mounting can be seen in Figure 3.

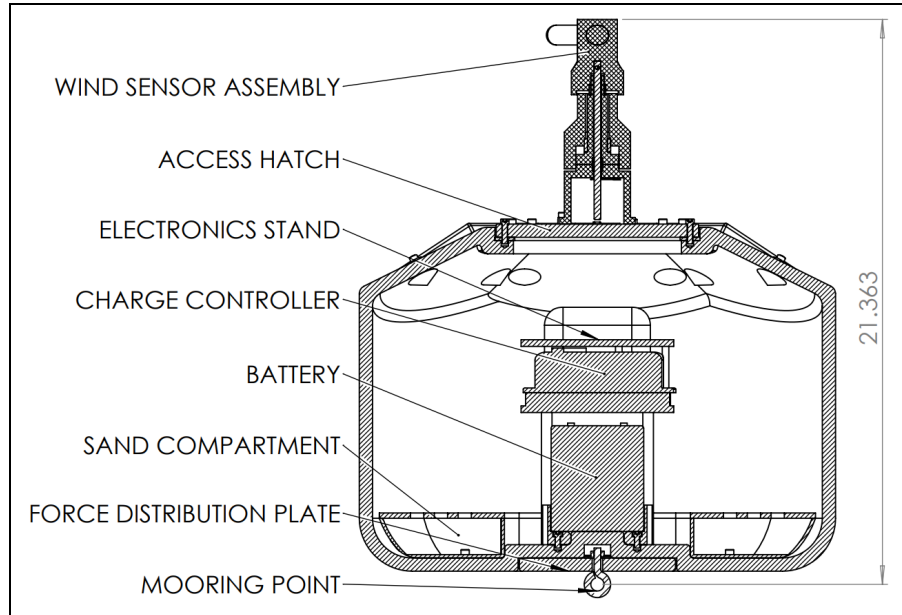


Figure 3: Buoy Cross Section

The electrical system is responsible for power generation, storage, and distribution. As well as sensor integration, and data transmission. An array of 12 solar panels were placed on a 25 degree slope around the top of the buoy. This was determined to be the optimal setup for a western Vancouver Island deployment. Each of the solar panels are connected in series to create a single maximally 72V input to the charge controller. The latter is used to regulate the charge and discharge of the 12V lithium iron phosphate battery as required throughout the deployment. To eliminate shading losses and loss of solar power due to panel failure in the series circuit, 100V 1A Schottky diodes are used as bypasses for each panel. Voltage from the battery is stepped down to 5V supplied to the raspberry pi pico W (Pi) using an adjustable buck converter. The Pi then supplied each of the sensors with the required 3V3 logic voltage using its onboard buck converter.

The Accelerometer, Gyroscope, Magnetometer, and Magnetic Encoder were all connected in series to the Pi on a common I2C communication network. The temperature probes, hall effect sensor, SD card, and LEDs were all connected individually to pins. Lastly, a button was added between the RST and GND pins on the Pi allowing the buoy to be kickstarted without the need for an external computer connection.

The software system for the low cost smart buoy was based on a collection and post process pipeline. This was done for the prototype in order to verify raw vs processed data but could easily be done in a single step. The collection code was run live on the buoy while the post processing was done on a laptop.

The buoy side software, developed in MicroPython for the Pi, manages a strict sampling sequence designed for power efficiency and data quality. The cycle starts with a five minute high frequency sampling of the 9-axis motion data at a nominal 10Hz. Next, the temperatures, wind speed, and wind direction were all sampled using a mix of hardware interrupts and direct sensor readings. All the collected data is then packaged into an extractable csv file saved on the local SD card. This allows the buoy to save a massive amount of data while remaining accessible to a wireless connection with the Pi.

The post processing pipeline consisted of many steps all executed in Python. Because the buoy is a non-stabilized floating, rotating, and rocking platform, raw acceleration data needs to be processed in order to be understandable and useful. A Mahony Fusion Filter is used to estimate the buoy's orientation (pitch, roll, heading) by fusing the accelerometer and gyroscope data with the magnetometer providing a heading reference. The script then generates a rotation matrix to rotate the body frame accelerations into the North East Down (NED) frame. This is essential in order to isolate the vertical displacement (heave) from the horizontal motion of the buoy. Once the vertical acceleration is isolated, the pipeline reconstructs the displacement with a frequency domain double integration. The final wave statistics are derived from this data using the WelchMethod to compute the Power Spectral Density (PSD). From this energy spectrum the significant wave height, peak period, and directional spectra can all be found. The final stage of the analysis is to tilt and correct the wind direction data. With the wind sensor being mounted to a moving structure, the angle read on the sensor is relative to the body fixed frame. Using the previously calculated data for a tilt corrected orientation the true wind direction can be found. The pipeline is summarized below in Figure 4. The pseudocode can be found in the Detailed Design Document.

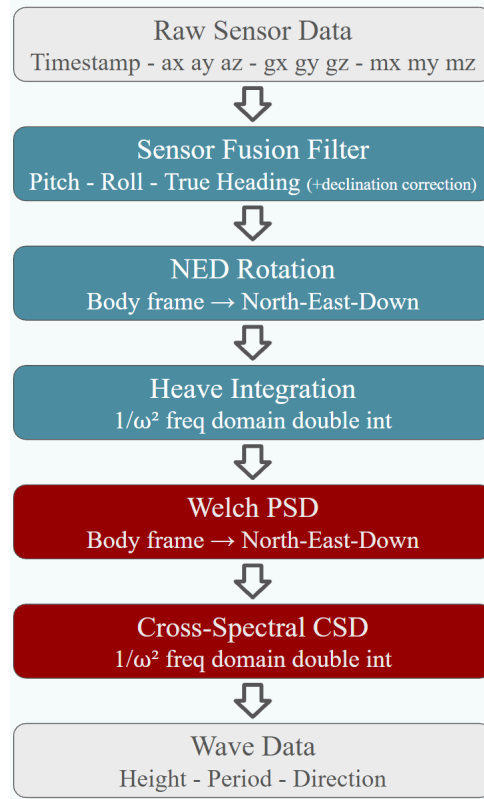


Figure 4: Data Processing Pipeline

3. Analysis Summary

In order to determine the battery and solar requirements of the buoy, a solar study was conducted. Adding up the power consumption and losses of the electrical system it was found that 13mV/h/day is required. A location of Port Renfrew was used as it represents a worst case scenario for sun throughout the year. With the 12 solar panels and the selected battery size, it was determined that the buoy would be able to be self-sustaining throughout a year. This is aided by the frequent sleep cycles used in the data collection process to conserve power. The energy throughout the year can be seen in Figure 5.

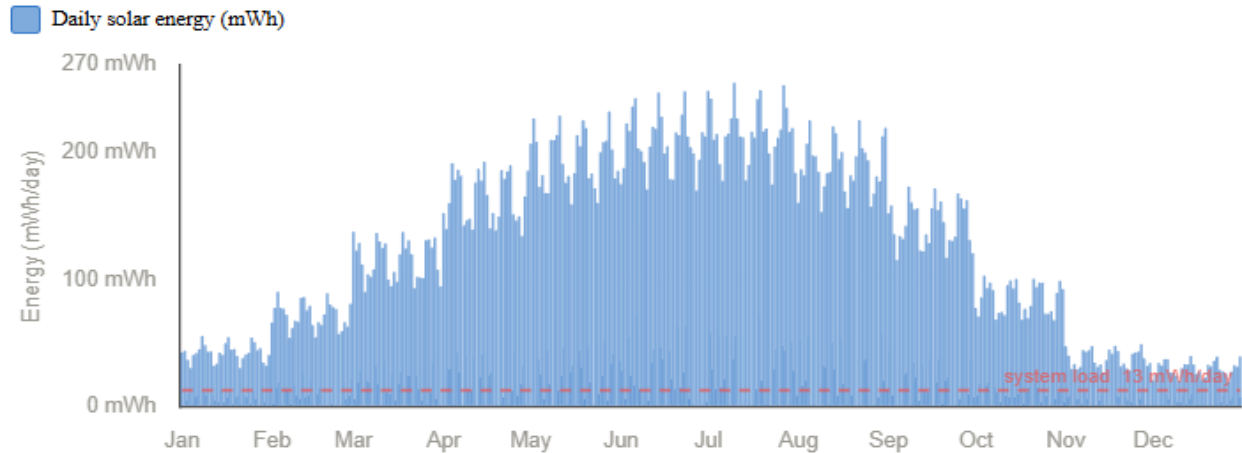


Figure 5: Solar Study

During the initial stages of the project, it was originally intended to include a wave power generation method into the buoy allowing for power generation in low sunlight conditions. After completing the solar study it was determined that the introduction of a complicated additional power source was unnecessary and came with too many risks. A wave generator would push the buoy's reaction to waves further away from following the true wave, introducing more complex situations to the data processing. The additional complex mechanical components created a high chance of water ingress leading to catastrophic failure of the entire buoy. With the ability to upsize the battery and the added risk, the idea was simplified to the seen solution.

After a discussion with UVic graduate students working on buoy design, it was suggested to use ProteusDS as a simulation software for the project. This software allows for the full simulation of the buoy and mooring line in any sea conditions. It was chosen to simulate the buoy in a worst case scenario in order to prove the capabilities and create the highest possible forces in the mooring line. After reviewing historical data of the area, "normal" operating condition was a tidal current of 0.5kt along with a 2.5m wave at a 10 second period. This situation was used to decide upon the buoyant force of the float and the mass of the mooring weight. This created a stable situation in which the buoy was able to maintain a predictable watch circle while still being easily deployable with a low mass. The worst case used to show the survivability of the buoy was a 5m wave in the same settings. The simulation can be seen in Figure 6.

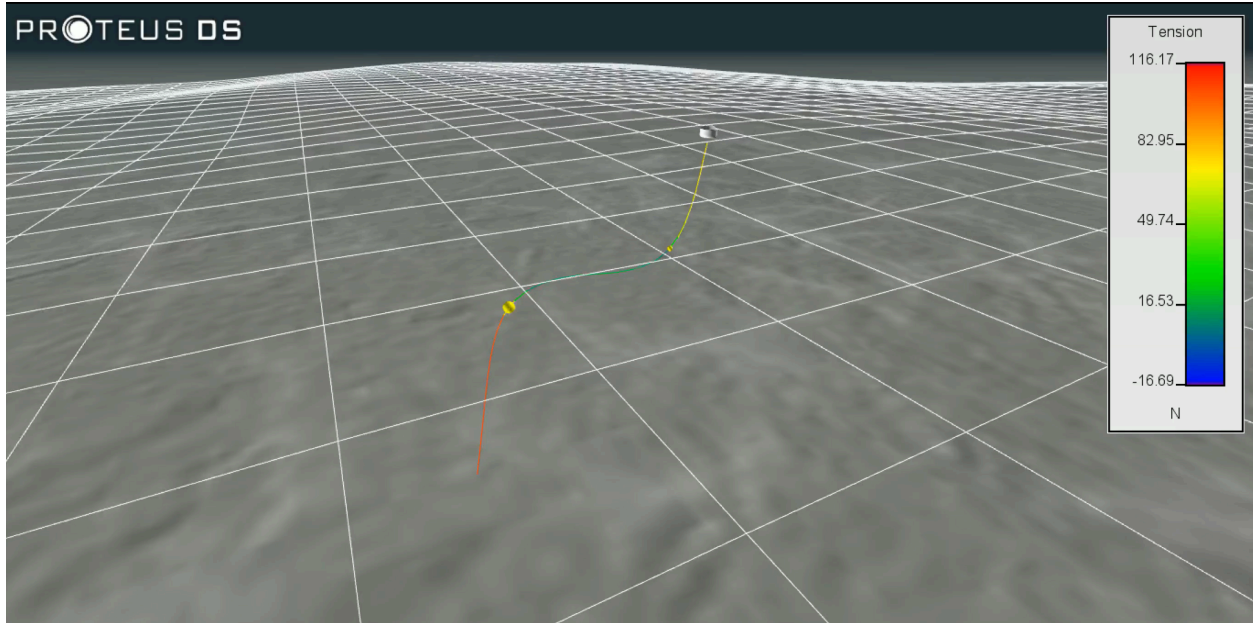


Figure 6: Proteus DS Simulation

ProteusDS also outputs the stress within the mooring line. This data was utilized to choose a mass required for the ocean floor anchor as well as the forces that will be transmitted through the buoy. An elemental Von-Mises stress analysis was used to simulate the stresses in the buoy hull. The analysis can be seen in Figure 7.

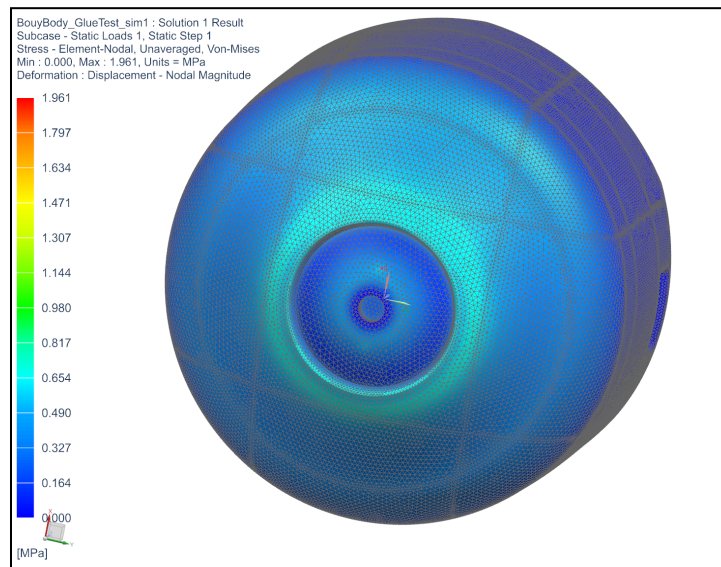


Figure 7: PLA Buoy Body Elemental-Nodal Stress

Finite element analysis (FEA) showed that the segmented PLA buoy design is structurally feasible under expected near-shore loading conditions. The maximum von Mises stress in the PLA hull was 1.96 MPa, which is significantly lower than the allowable stress of ~6 MPa. The allowable stress of 6 MPa was calculated from PLA yield strength data (Granta EduPack) with an applied safety factor to

account for variability in 3D printed material behaviour, resulting in a safety factor of 3.05. Similarly, stresses within the glued joints were only 0.251 MPa, well below the maximum bonding stress of the epoxy at 46 MPa. This confirmed that the bonded multi-part construction is a viable manufacturing approach.

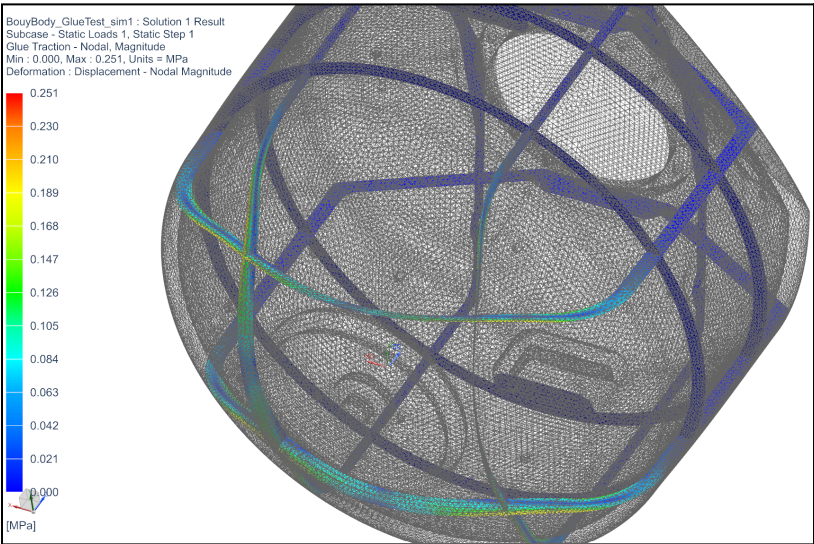


Figure 8: PLA Buoy Body Glue Traction Results

4. Risk, Reliability, and Safety Considerations

From the table shown below, the results of this risk assessment highlight that the project is feasible but inherently sensitive to environmental conditions and mechanical fatigue. The magnitude of severeness of the failures was calculated by multiplying the severity by occurrence of the failure by the detection. This allowed the calculation of the greatest failure being the hull form failing in any way which will create an entire system failure. The following rows highlight other risks in the project that can cause potential failures in the design.

Table 1 : Failure modes and effects analysis

FMEA									
Severity (S): 1 = negligible, 10 = major damage									
Occurance (O): 1 = rare, 10 = frequent									
Detection (D): 1 = very likely, 10 = difficult									
RPN = S x O x D (higher = priority)									
Subsystem / Function	Failure Mode	Effect on System	Likely Causes	Current Controls	S	O	D	RPN	Recommended Actions / Mitigation
Energy harvesting	Insufficient average power	Sensors/transmission dropouts; fails "self-sufficient" objective	Low sea state, low conversion efficiency, mechanical losses	Power budget estimate; modelling	9	5	4	180	Increase energy storage margin; duty-cycle sensing; reduce friction; optimize gearing/rectification; validate with wave cases
Energy harvesting	Mechanism jams / binds	No power generation; potential structural overload	Corrosion, debris ingestion, misalignment, tolerance stack-up	Basic sealing; CAD clearances	8	4	7	224	Add debris guards; corrosion-resistant bearings; alignment features; physical end-stops; bench test in salt spray conditions
Energy harvesting	Excessive peak loads	Component failure (shaft/arm/bearings), reduced life	Large waves, resonance, hard stops	Preliminary load assumptions	8	4	6	192	Add torque limiting / compliant element; revise load cases; increase SF on critical parts; avoid hard stops
Mooring system	Mooring line overload / snap	Buoy drifts away; total mission failure	High current/wind, wave surge, insufficient scope	Basic sizing	10	3	6	180	Size for worst-case; add chafe protection; use elastic/snubber; proof-test; include secondary retention line if feasible
Mooring system	Anchor drags / slips	Buoy location inaccurate; drift	Wrong anchor type, seabed mismatch	Assumed seabed	9	4	6	216	Define seabed assumptions; choose appropriate anchor; increase scope; add retrieval + re-set plan; consider heavier anchor margin
Stability	Buoy does not self-right	Sensors out of water; mechanical damage; poor data	CG too high, insufficient ballast, wave torque	CAD concept	9	3	5	135	Verify GM / restoring moment; add ballast low; widen waterplane; test tilt response in simulation + tank
Waterproofing	Water ingress (electronics)	Shorting, corrosion, data loss	Seal failure, condensation, improper assembly	IP intent; enclosure concept	10	3	7	210	Use gasketed enclosure + cable glands; conformal coat PCB; pressure/leak test; desiccant + vent strategy
Comms	Data link intermittent	"Near real-time" fails; gaps in dataset	Coverage gaps, antenna orientation, power saving	Basic comms plan	6	5	4	120	Buffer data onboard; retransmit logic; antenna placement; send summaries; tune update rate to power budget
Sensors	Sensor drift / inaccurate readings	Wrong wave/wind outputs	Calibration drift, mounting issues, water splash	Manufacturer specs	7	4	6	168	Calibration procedure; mechanical isolation; shielding; validation against known references; filtering approach documented
Materials	Corrosion / fastener seizure	Increased friction, leaks, mechanical failure	Galvanic pairs, wrong coatings	"Marine-grade" intent	7	5	6	210	Standardize materials (316 SS, appropriate plastics); isolate dissimilar metals; anti-seize; anodizing/coatings; rinse/maintenance plan
Power storage	Battery capacity fade / failure	Reduced uptime; safety concern	Temperature exposure, deep cycling	Battery spec	8	3	6	144	Keep within SOC limits; include BMS; thermal placement; conservative capacity margin; logging battery health

Table 2: HARA

HARA							
Severity (S): 1 = minor, 10 = serious injury / major environmental harm							
Likelihood (L): 1 = unlikely, 5 = likely							
Risk = S x L (higher = priority)							
Hazard	Hazardous Event (Scenario)	Who/What is at Risk	Primary Causes	S (1-5)	L (1-5)	Risk	Safety Controls / Mitigations
Manual handling injury	Lifting/carrying buoy causes strain or drop	Deployer	Too heavy, awkward grip points	3	3	9	One-person mass target; handles; lift points; safe deployment procedure; keep sharp edges removed
Entanglement / trip hazard	Mooring line causes entanglement during deployment/retrieval	Deployer	Slack line, poor line management	3	2	6	Line management plan; gloves; keep line coiled; clear deployment steps; avoid loose loops
Pinch points	Fingers pinched by moving arm/mechanism during testing	Team members	Exposed moving parts, no guard	3	2	6	Guards/covers; lockout during handling; labels; keep moving parts internal where possible
Uncontrolled drift	Buoy breaks free and becomes a navigation hazard	Public/environment	Mooring failure, anchor drag	4	2	8	Overdesign mooring; chafe protection; secondary tether; bright marking; GPS beacon if feasible; recovery plan
Water ingress electrical fault	Short occurs after water intrusion	Device (and low shock risk)	Seal failure, condensation	2	2	4	Low-voltage design; fused lines; sealed enclosure; leak testing; conformal coating; BMS protections
Battery chemical release	Battery damage leads to leakage	Environment	Mechanical impact, seal failure	5	1	5	Use robust battery pack with BMS; protective housing; secure mounting; avoid crush zones; retrieval plan
Wildlife interaction	Wildlife entangles with line or contacts buoy	Wildlife	Exposed slack line; protrusions	4	2	8	Minimize loose lines; smooth exterior; avoid net-like features; use marine-safe materials; keep profile compact
Corrosion / material toxicity	Material degrades and sheds contaminants	Environment	Wrong plastics/metals, coatings	4	2	8	Marine-safe non-toxic materials; corrosion-resistant metals; compatible coatings; document materials selection
Severe sea state operation	High waves cause impacts or unexpected motion during retrieval	Deployer	Retrieval in unsafe conditions	4	2	8	Retrieval limits; "do not retrieve above X conditions"; procedure; PPE; plan around weather windows
Sharp edges	Cuts during assembly or deployment	Team/deployer	Unfinished edges, exposed fasteners	2	3	6	Deburr; edge radii; caps on fasteners; assembly checklist

The development of a buoy hazard analysis starts by defining the operational scope and identifying environmental risks such as heavy swell impact or saltwater corrosion. This initial phase leads into a systematic identification of failure modes like mooring line snaps or sensor malfunctions that could compromise safety. Each risk is evaluated based on its potential severity and the likelihood of occurrence to prioritize critical design requirements. From this our group will implement specific control measures including redundant tethering systems and waterproof enclosures to mitigate these high-priority threats. The process concludes with a validation plan that uses real-time diagnostic data and scheduled maintenance to ensure the buoy operates reliably in unpredictable marine conditions.

5. Summary and Lessons Learned

The project successfully met the primary goal of developing, constructing, and deploying a functional low cost smart buoy for a total cost less than \$1000. By integrating a 3D printed hull with a Raspberry Pi Pico based electronics setup, a custom purpose built data collection and processing pipeline was created. The entire system demonstrated the ability to capture real deployment data and calculate the wave height, peak period, swell direction, wind direction, wind speed, as well as air and internal

temperatures. The successful deployment and testing proved the ability of the electrical system to charge the battery using solar power while maintaining a constant and reliable power supply to the controller and sensors.

While the prototype successfully demonstrated the ability to collect environmental data, there were some discrepancies observed between the measured and expected wave data. The most significant deviation occurred in the measurement of wave height, which showed greater variability than expected when compared to reference data online at the time and location of testing. The discrepancy is likely due to limitations in the accelerometer sensing method, as well as the influence of the mooring line tension. The mooring line configuration constrained the natural response of the buoy wave excitation, reducing the accuracy of the wave height estimates. Additionally, small amounts of sensor noise and calibration may have contributed to variation in the measured data. This suggests that future iterations could improve accuracy through refinement of filtering methods, improved calibration, and optimization of the mooring configuration to better isolate wave-induced motion.

With the cross disciplinary nature of this project there were a few lessons learned by the team throughout the process of design and construction of the buoy. The largest lesson learned was that data processing plays a massive role in the ability of the system to deliver useful information. Without the meticulous implementation of a buoy specific coordinate frame transformation, tilt correction, and spectral analysis, the raw data remains functionally useless for research. If this project was pursued further, it would be incredibly useful to calculate the proper dynamic damping ratios of the buoy which could be used to inform the processing further.

Another lesson learned during the construction process was the use of a jigsaw multi-part 3D print. When assembling parts sliced using the jigsaw pattern, each part was constrained in one plane but not in the other. This led to a large amount of sliding and misalignment as the layers were added. It would be beneficial to implement a dowel pin style connection to allow for a fully limited motion upon connection of the pieces.

If this prototype was destined for mass production and more real world deployments, there is a main consideration that would lead to a large improvement in reliability and risk minimization. This would be the material choice of the hull. It is recommended that the main hull be rotationally molded using polyethylene in the same manner that white water kayaks are made. This would create a robust waterproof hull designed to deal with impacts from waves and logs. The suggestion is also based on the availability of these materials and the widespread use of this method of manufacturing.

Detailed Design Documentation

Department of Mechanical Engineering

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MECH 400B Capstone Design



Detailed Design Documentation

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Low Cost Smart Buoy

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1. Client Objectives and Engineering Requirements

Table 1: Design Objectives

ID	Objective Statement	Category	Units
OBJ-1	Measure wave height, period, and direction to characterize surf conditions.	Performance	$m, s, ^\circ$
OBJ-2	Measure wind speed and direction at the buoy location.	Performance	$kph, ^\circ$
OBJ-3	Measure water and air temperature.	Performance	$^\circ C$
OBJ-4	Transmit collected data to the user in near real time.	Performance	-
OBJ-5	Generate renewable energy to operate self-sufficiently.	Power & Operation	W
OBJ-6	Operate continuously for extended durations without recharging.	Power & Operation	hours
OBJ-7	Require minimal maintenance and cleaning.	Power & Operation	-
OBJ-8	Be portable enough for one person to carry and deploy safely	Usability	kg
OBJ-9	Allow setup and activation within a short period of time.	Usability	min
OBJ-10	Remain upright and self-right after disturbance from waves.	Durability & Safety	$^\circ$
OBJ-11	Remain functional in large-wave, high-wind conditions.	Durability & Safety	Sea State
OBJ-12	Maintain waterproof integrity and resist corrosion.	Durability & Safety	IPX rating
OBJ-13	Use marine safe non-toxic materials wherever possible.	Durability & Safety	-
OBJ-14	Keep total prototype cost below approximately \$1,000 CAD.	Economic	\$

Table 2: Engineering Requirements

ID	Requirement Statement	Units/Target	Verification Method
REQ-1	The buoy shall measure wave height from 0-4 m with $\pm 5\%$ accuracy	m	Test sensor in a tank of known wave size
REQ-2	The buoy shall measure wave period 0-60 s with $\pm 5\%$ accuracy	s	Test sensor in a tank of known wave size
REQ-3	The buoy shall measure wind speed 0-100 kph $\pm 5\%$	kph	Compare anemometers
REQ-4	The buoy shall measure wind direction 0-360° $\pm 5^\circ$	°	Compass alignment
REQ-5	The buoy shall measure air temperature -30°C - 30°C $\pm 1^\circ\text{C}$	°C	Compare thermometer
REQ-6	The buoy shall measure water temperature 0°C - 30°C $\pm 1^\circ\text{C}$	°C	Compare thermometer
REQ-7	The buoy shall transmit processed environmental data in near real time (≥ 6 updates per minute, ≤ 5 s latency @ 1 km.).	updates/min, s	Communication test
REQ-8	The buoy shall generate ≥ 10 W of solar power under typical daylight conditions	W	Power measurement via multimeter
REQ-9	The buoy shall store sufficient energy for ≥ 168 hours (7 days) of autonomous operation	hours	Test and measure battery storage
REQ-10	The buoy shall require no manual maintenance for ≥ 14 days	days	Field and data observation
REQ-11	The buoy's total mass shall not exceed 25 kg to allow single-user handling	kg	Physical weighing
REQ-12	The buoy shall be deployable by one person within 15 minutes from initial water contact to system activation.	min	Timed deployment
REQ-13	The buoy shall self-right from 180° heel angle within 10 seconds	°/s	Timed tilt test

REQ-14	The buoy shall remain functional in Sea State 7 conditions	Sea State	Field/wave simulation
REQ-15	The buoy shall be waterproof to IPX-8 standard	IPX rating	Submersion test
REQ-16	All materials in contact with seawater shall be non-toxic and marine-safe.	-	Material spec and compliance review
REQ-17	The buoy shall maintain full functional capability for ≥ 1 year of normal near-shore operation and maintenance.	Year	Material durability review/long-term simulation
REQ-18	The prototype cost shall not exceed \$1,000 CAD	\$	Cost analysis

2. Drawings and CAD Models

A complete CAD model was created using SOLIDWORKS. This was used to generate all of the required 3D prints to assemble the buoy in its entirety. This same model was used to create all drawings submitted to the UVic Machine Shop. Every part designed by the team can be found below.

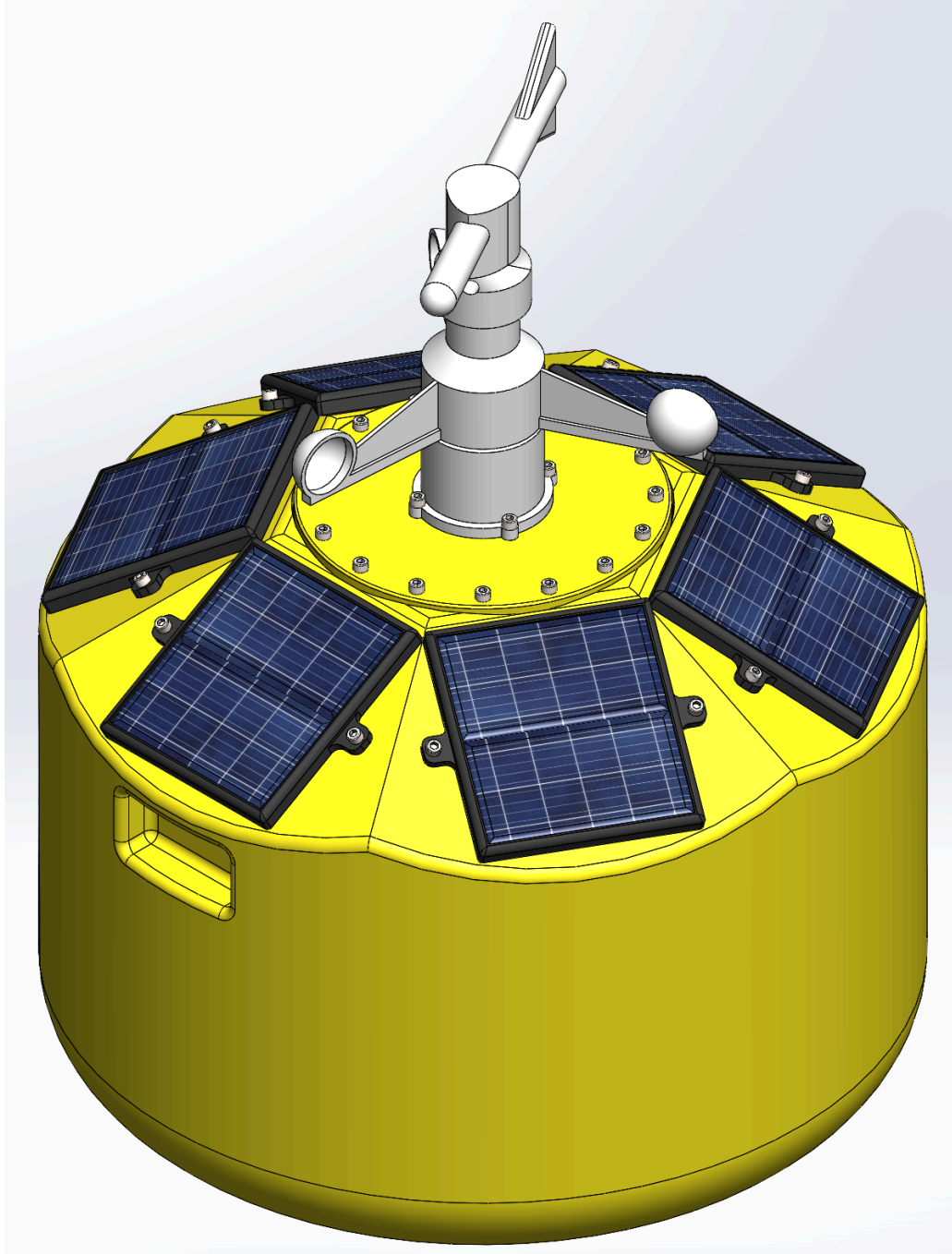


Figure 1: Complete CAD Model

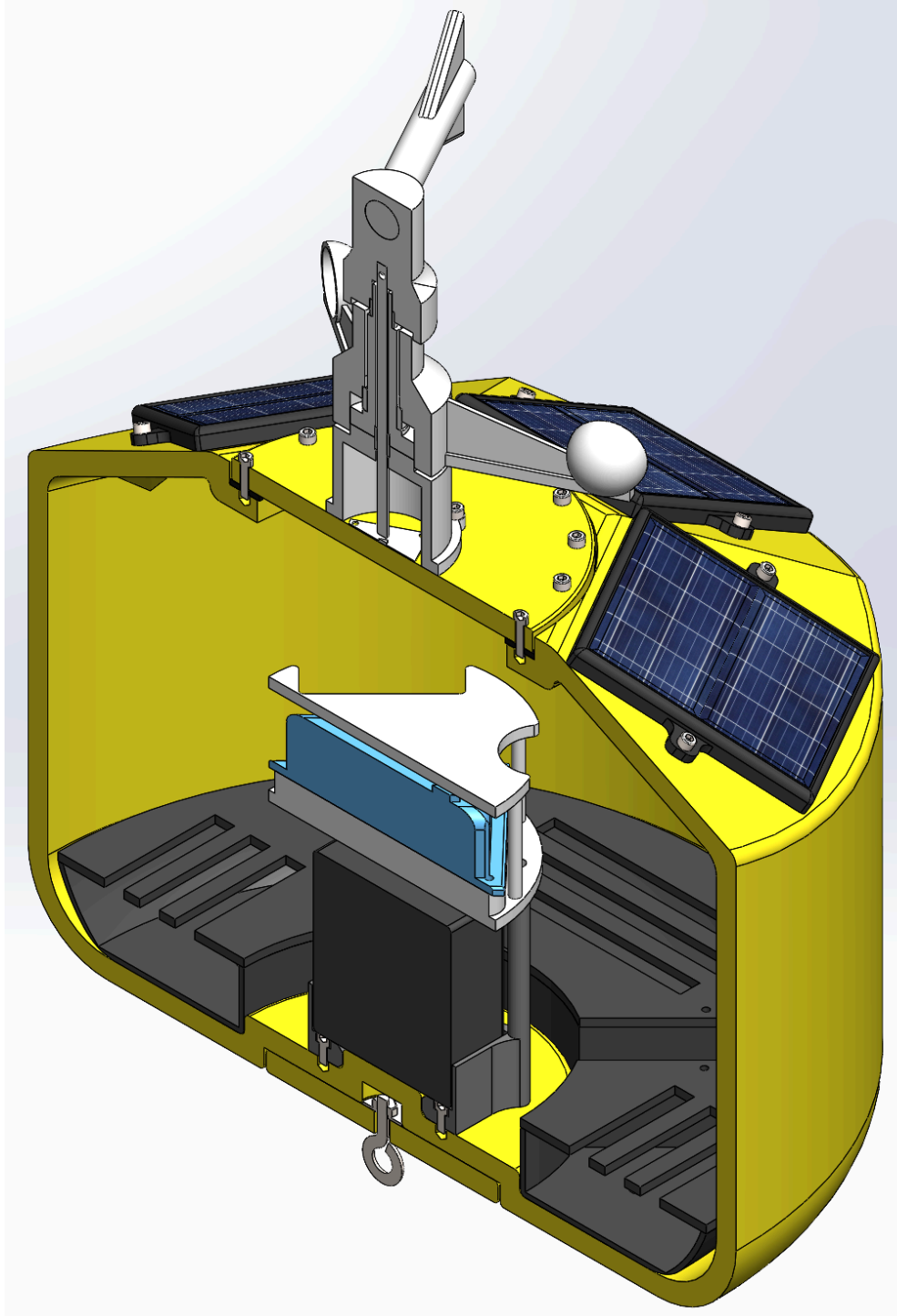


Figure 2: Complete CAD Model Cross-Section

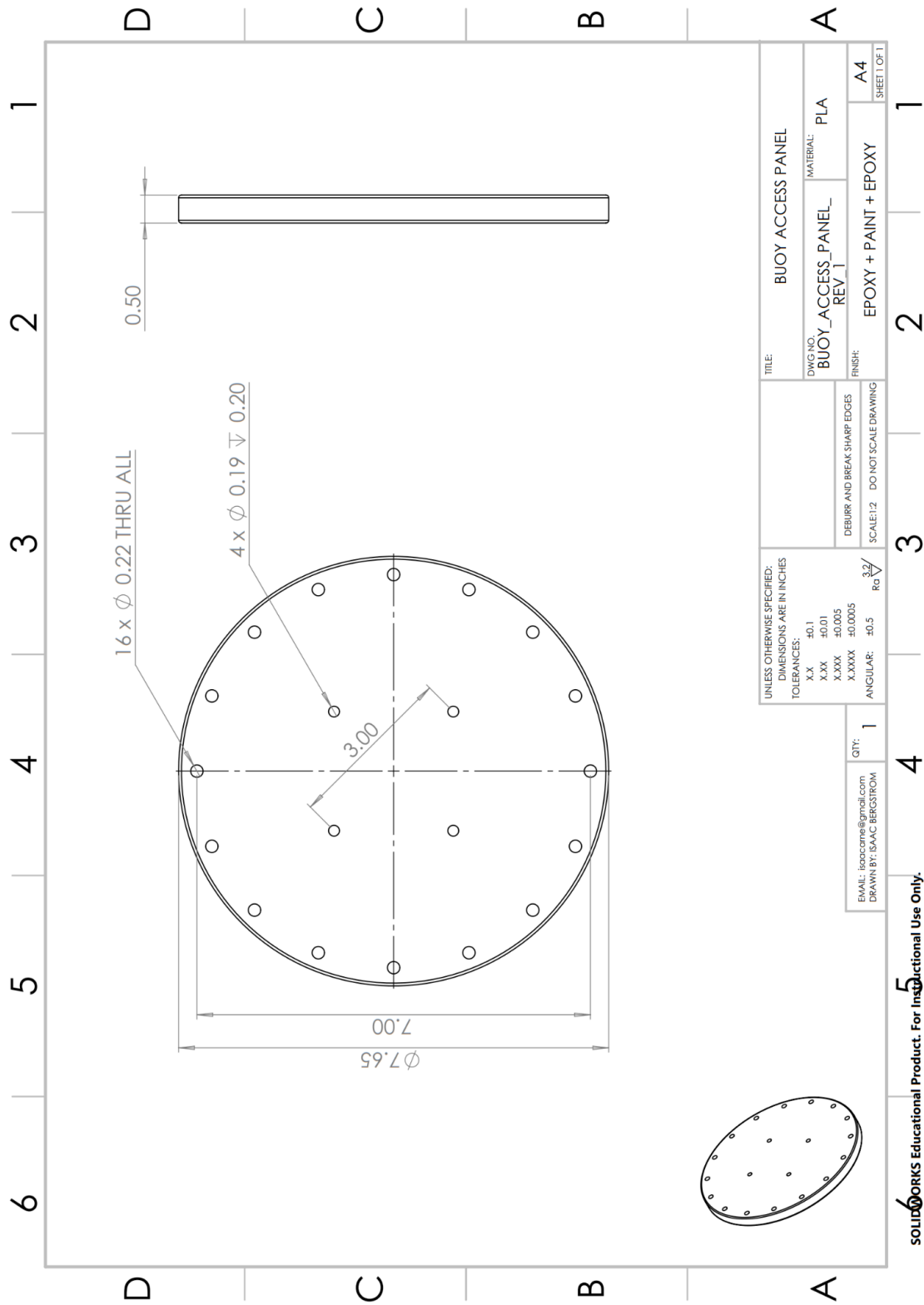


Figure 4: Access Panel Engineering Drawing

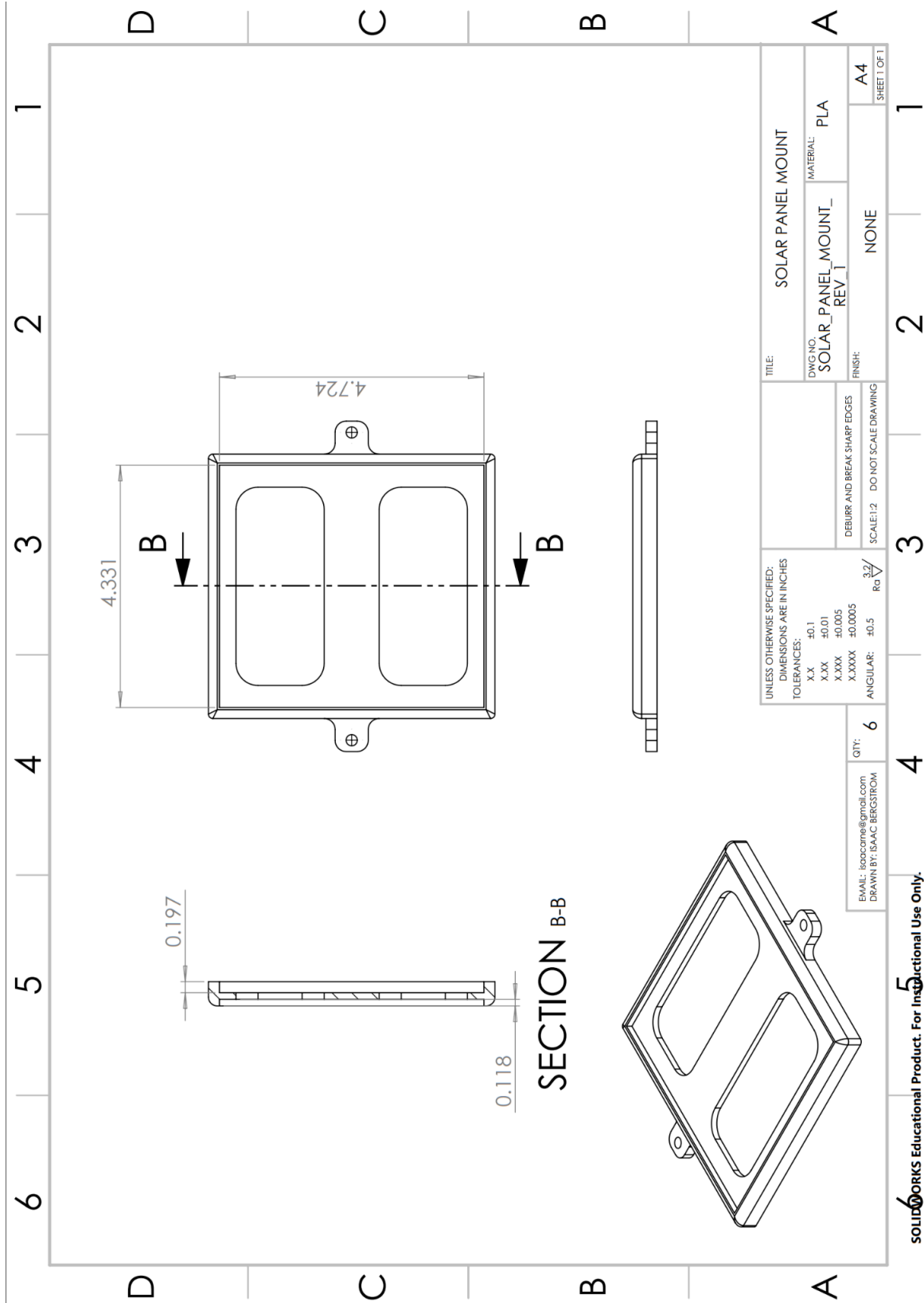


Figure 5: Solar Panel Mount Engineering Drawing

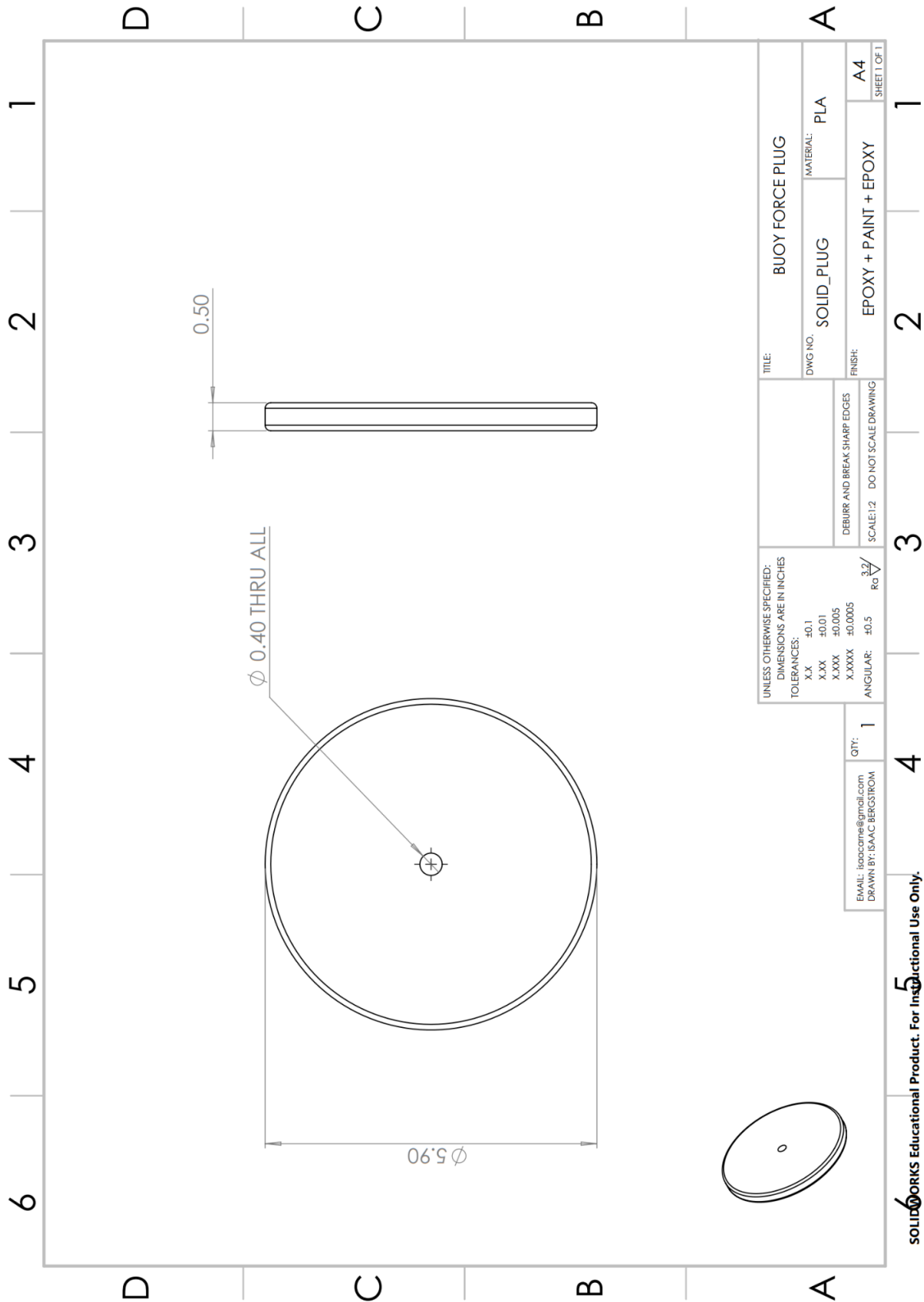


Figure 6: Force Plate Engineering Drawing

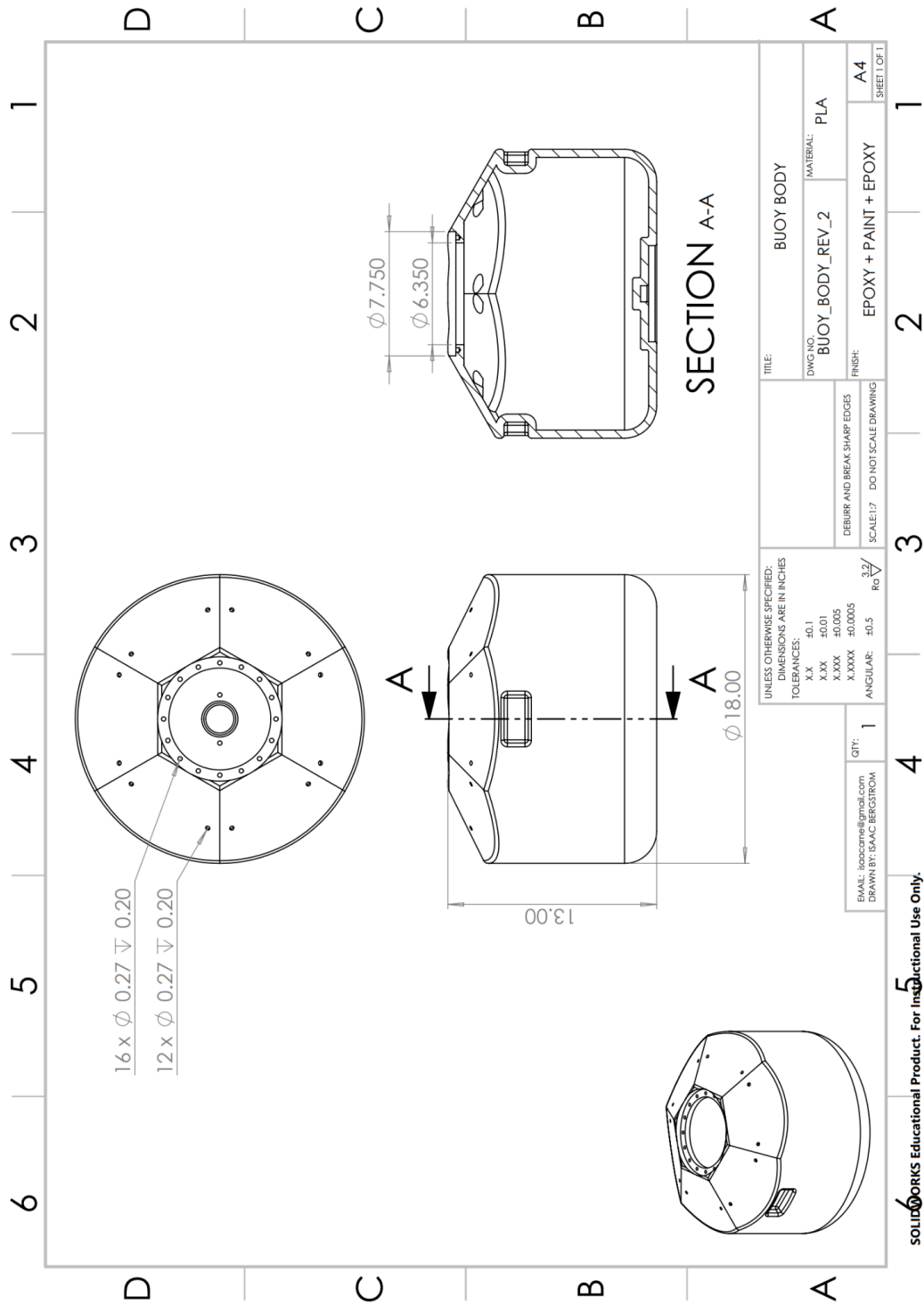


Figure 7: Buoy Hull Engineering Drawing

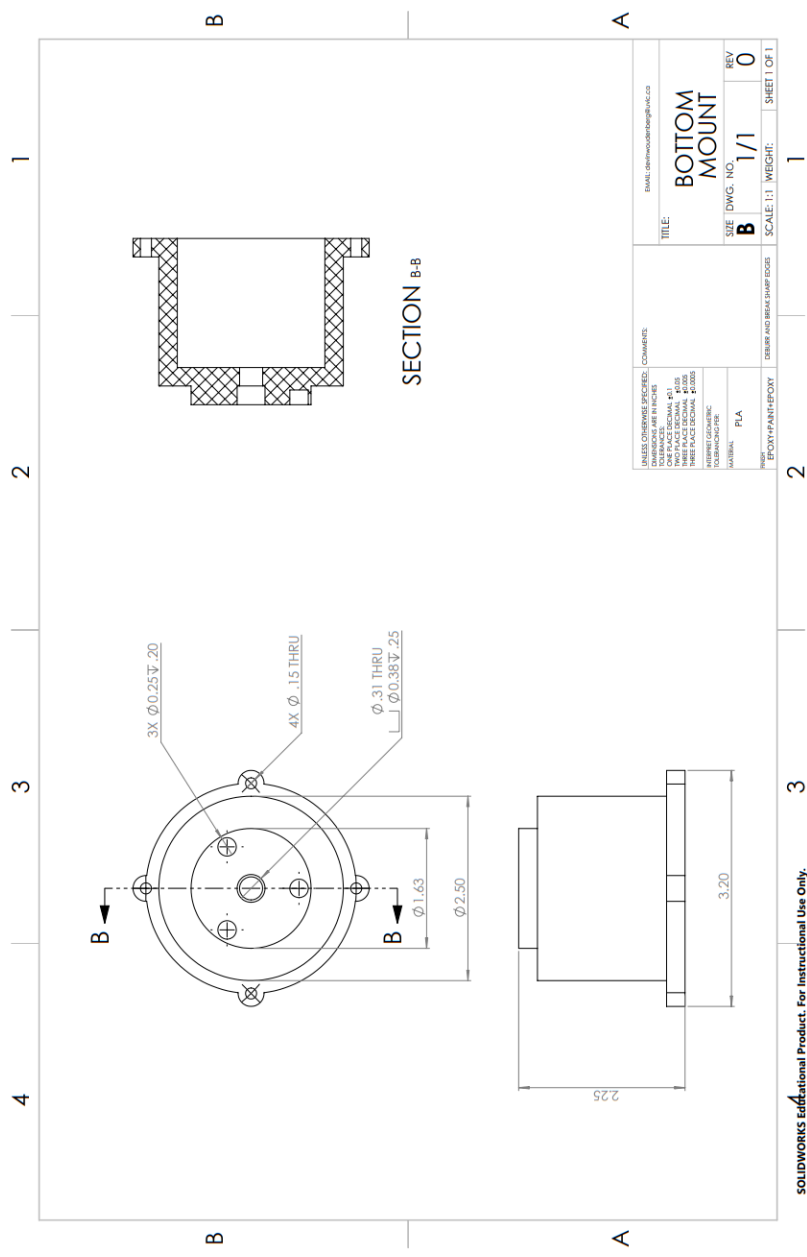


Figure 9: Bottom Mount for Wind Tester

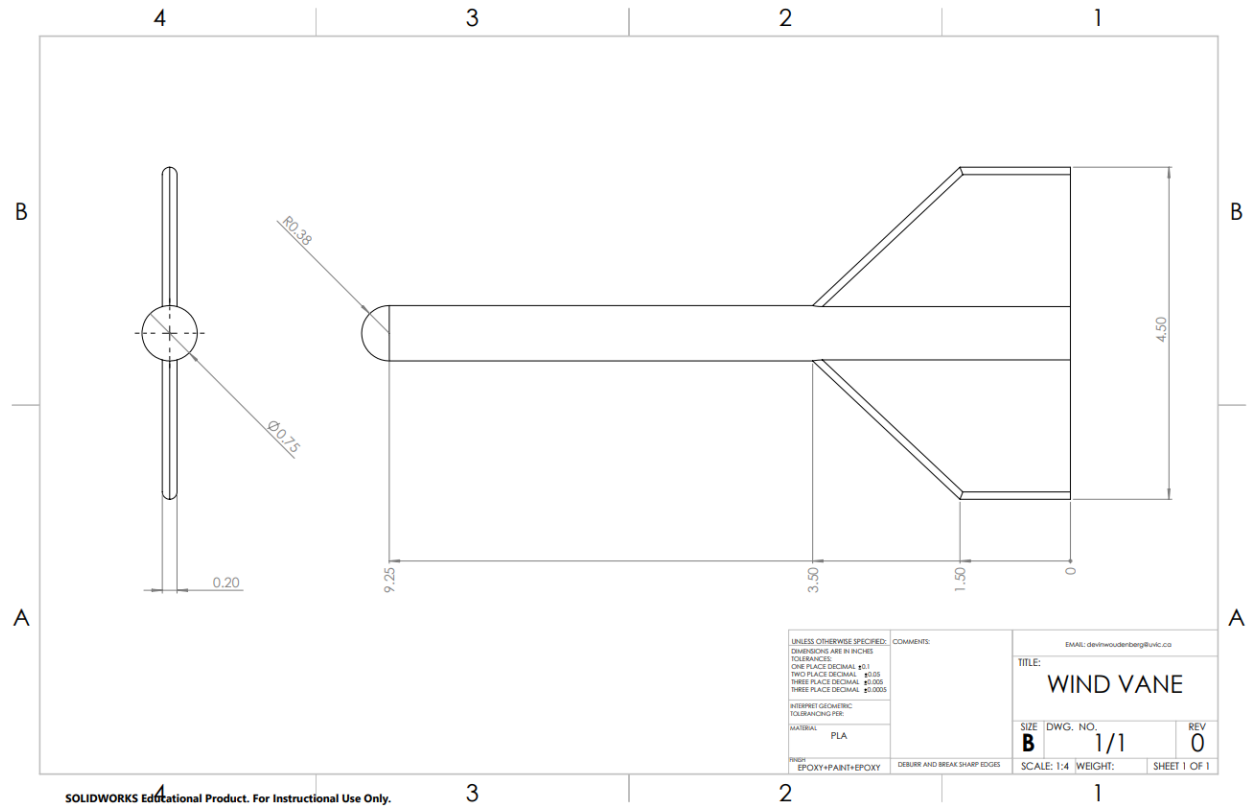


Figure 13: Wind Vane for Wind Tester

3. Circuit Diagrams and Pseudocode

The complete code pipeline explanation can be found in detail in the Final Report. Please refer to this document for a more detailed explanation of the process.

3.1. Data Collection Code

Hardware Initialization:

- Initialize LED's (yellow for sampling, red for errors)
- Initialize SD card via SPI
- Initialize the IMU, Magnetometer, and Magnetic encoder via I2C
- Setup DS18B20 temperature probes
- Load accelerometer, gyroscope, and magnetometer calibration values.

Functions:

- ReadPositional: Read the raw accelerometer, magnetometer, and gyroscope values accounting for the calibration
- ReadTemperatures: Reads the raw temperature values from the two probes

- ReadWindDirection: Sample the wind vane for a set duration and calculate the average wind direction using sine/cosine averaging
- ReadWindSpeed: Read interrupts to calculate the number of “clicks” that have happened on the hall effect sensor

Main Cycle:

1. Create a new CSV file on the SD card
2. Turn on yellow LED to signal sampling starting
3. Read Motion for 5 minutes
 - a. Read values at a rate of 10Hz
 - b. Collect wind data during last 30 seconds
 - c. Save all raw values to the CSV file
4. Read and save Temperatures using “ReadTemperatures” function
5. Collect wind data
 - a. Use ReadWindDirection to get the average wind direction
 - b. Use ReadWindSpeed to collect the wind speed average
 - c. Save all values to the CSV file
6. Turn yellow LED off to signal sampling done
7. Close write access to the CSV file
8. Rest for 2 minutes to conserve power
9. Repeat steps 1-9 indefinitely

3.2. Data Processing Code

1. Configuration and constants
 - a. Define gravity and magnetic declination (based on geographic location)
 - b. Set calibration values for wind direction and speed
 - c. Set highpass cutoff for heave to filter out noise
 - d. Set warmup time to trim out unstable sensor data during fusion
2. Load data
 - a. Read the csv line by line, collecting the positional data, temperatures, and wind data
 - b. Calculate the actual sampling rate by finding the time between timestamps
3. Coordinate & Attitude Processing
 - a. Pass raw data through the fusion filter to calculate pitch, roll, and true heading
 - b. Discard the warmup time to remove unstable filter noise
 - c. Perform a coordinate frame rotation to get the Body Frame into the NED (North East Down) coordinate frame

4. Wave Data Processing
 - a. Isolate the vertical acceleration and double integrate to get displacement
 - b. Derive the NED slopes of the water surface by rotating pitch and roll by the current heading
 - c. Use the Welch method to compute the power spectral density of the heave
 - d. Calculate the significant wave height and peak period using the results of Welch
 - e. Use cross spectral density to find wave direction at each frequency
 - f. Identify the swell peaks and their specific directions
5. Environmental data
 - a. Take the raw wind vane angle and apply tilt correction to get “true” wind direction
 - b. Calculate the average wind speed using linear calibration formula
6. Create Outputs
 - a. Print a formatted summary of the significant wave height, period, swell peaks, and temperatures
 - b. Generate plots that show calculated data
 - i. Raw IMU data
 - ii. Fused Attitude (after fusion)
 - iii. Attitude after NED rotation
 - iv. Vertical heave displacement
 - v. Wave energy spectrum and directional scatter

3.3. Electrical Wiring & Schematic

The final wiring setup utilizes a “75V | 10A” Victron maximum power point tracking (MPPT) solar charge controller to filter and regulate any generated solar power, producing between 13.5 and 14.4 volts for 12 volt battery charging, maintenance, and also for directly powering the buoy’s onboard systems directly if the battery is fully charged or depleted. Solar power is generated utilizing twelve 6V 1W solar panels wired in series, each with a bypass 100 volt, 1 amp Schottky diode to minimize power losses associated with panel shading, or complete solar loss due to panel failure (which would interrupt the series circuit). This system produces a maximum solar charge of 72V at 12W.

To generate the 3.3 volt signal needed for the Raspberry Pi microcontroller and associated peripherals from the battery or solar charger supplied voltage, a Recom R78K3.3-1.0 buck converter was planned to be utilized, along with filtering media. Due to incidental failure of the Recom converter late into the prototyping process, a XL4015 discrete adjustable buck converter was used in its place to generate a 5V signal to power both the microcontroller and MicroSD card reader. The switching converter onboard the microcontroller is then used to generate the necessary 3.3V for the remaining peripherals.

Power losses due to this change are minor ($\sim 0.10\text{W}$ max usage) and are not expected to change the outcome of objectives and requirements related to battery life. For future designs, it is recommended that a Recom R78K5.0-1.0 and R78K3.3-1.0 be used to generate the required 5V and 3.3V signals to reduce unnecessary power losses.

Communication between the microcontroller and sensors is achieved using a two wire I2C bus, while data is written from the former to the MicroSD card writer using a four wire SPI bus. For sensors with integrated analog to digital converters, filtering capacitors are placed off their supply voltage lines to reduce low to medium frequency noise.

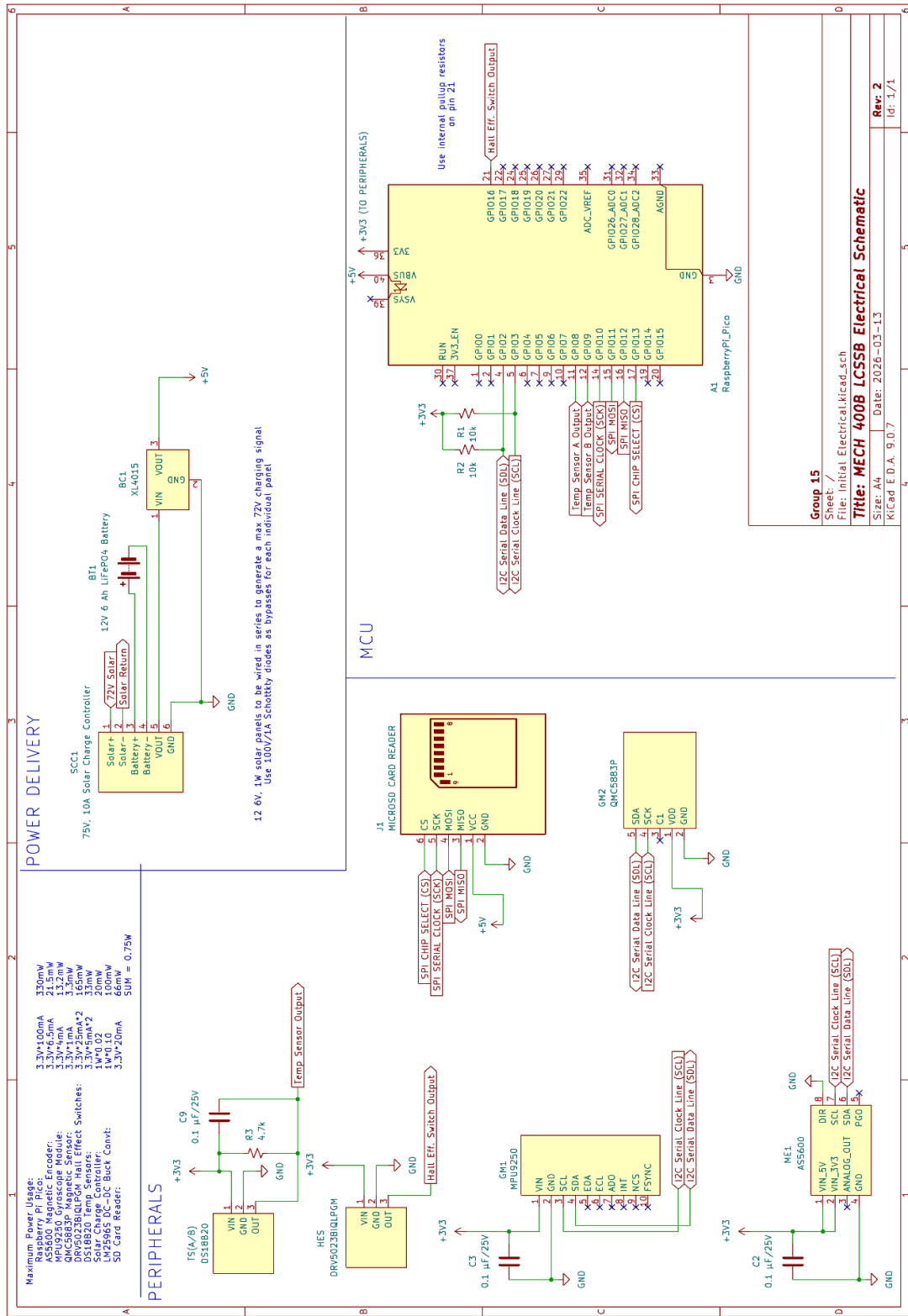


Figure 14: Electrical Schematic

3.4. Data Processing Pipeline

As outlined in the testing plan, all processing was done after collection in order to optimize the untested processing pipeline after collection. This process is also described in the previous section's pseudocode. The code was completed using micropython along with micropython libraries [1-5].

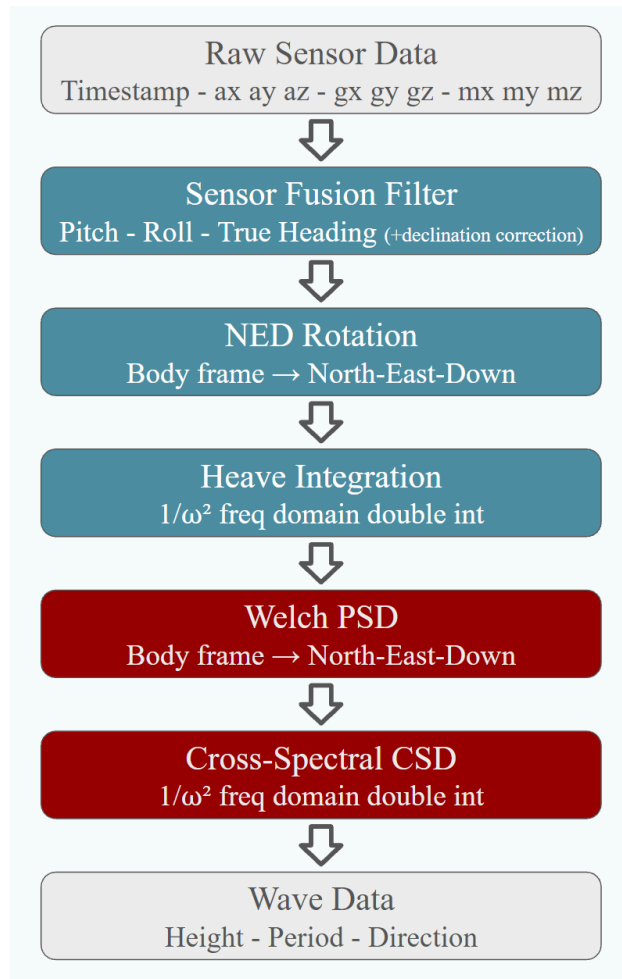


Figure 15: Data Processing Pipeline

4. Bill of Materials and Part Sources

A bill of materials (BOM) is shown in the below figure. This includes all parts used on the final deployed iteration of the low cost smart buoy. Parts that were 3D printed were all printed in the UVic Makerspace using PLA.

Table 3 : Final Buoy BOM

Part Name	Quantity	Source
Buoy Hull	1	3D printing + Epoxy
Buoy Access Panel	1	3D Printing
Buoy Force Dispersion Plate	1	3D Printing
Battery Holder	1	3D printing
Electronics Mounting Plate	1	3D printing
Sand Compartment	4	3D Printing
Sand Compartment Lid	4	3D Printing
Solar Panel Mount	6	3D Printing
Wind Sensor Base	1	3D Printing
Wind Sensor Scoops	1	3D Printing
Wind Sensor Top	1	3D Printing
Wind Sensor Vein	1	3D Printing
Wind Sensor Shaft	1	Machine Shop
Wind Sensor Small Bushing	1	Machine Shop
Wind Sensor Large Bushing	1	Machine Shop
Socket Head Cap Screw #6-32 x 1.5	1	Borrowed from AUVic
Socket Head Cap Screw #10-32 x 0.75	16	Borrowed from AUVic
Socket Head Cap Screw #10-32 x 0.5	28	Borrowed from AUVic
$\frac{3}{8}$ inch Eye Bolt with Nut	1	Canadian Tire
Heat Inserts #10-32	50	Amazon
Gasket Material	1	Amazon
10 Victron MPPT Charge Controller	1	Amazon
12V LiFePO 4.6 Ah Battery	1	Amazon
12-5V DC Converter	1	Mechatronics Lab

DS18X20 Temperature Probe	2	Amazon
MPU6500 Accelerometer/ Gyroscope	1	Amazon
QMC5883P Magnetometer	1	Digikey
AS5600 Magnetic Encoder	1	Digikey
MicroSD TF Card Module	1	Amazon
DRV5023 Hall Effect Sensor	1	Digikey
Red LED	1	Mechatronics Kit
Yellow LED	1	Mechantronics Kit
1W 6V Solar Panels	12	Amazon
Mooring Line	1	Canadian Tire
Connection Wire	6ft	Digikey
Raspberry Pi Pico W	1	UVic

5. Risk Assessment

From the table shown below, the results of this risk assessment highlight that the project is feasible but inherently sensitive to environmental conditions and mechanical fatigue. The magnitude of severeness of the failures was calculated by multiplying the severity by occurrence of the failure by the detection. This allowed the calculation of the greatest failure being the hull form failing in any way which will create an entire system failure. The following rows highlight other risks in the project that can cause potential failures in the design.

Table 4 : Failure modes and effects analysis

FMEA									
Severity (S): 1 = negligible, 10 = major damage									
Occurance (O): 1 = rare, 10 = frequent									
Detection (D): 1 = very likely, 10 = difficult									
RPN = S x O x D (higher = priority)									
Subsystem / Function	Failure Mode	Effect on System	Likely Causes	Current Controls	S	O	D	RPN	Recommended Actions / Mitigation
Energy harvesting	Insufficient average power	Sensors/transmission dropouts; fails "self-sufficient" objective	Low sea state, low conversion efficiency, mechanical losses	Power budget estimate; modelling	9	5	4	180	Increase energy storage margin; duty-cycle sensing; reduce friction; optimize gearing/rectification; validate with wave cases
Energy harvesting	Mechanism jams / binds	No power generation; potential structural overload	Corrosion, debris ingestion, misalignment, tolerance stack-up	Basic sealing; CAD clearances	8	4	7	224	Add debris guards; corrosion-resistant bearings; alignment features; physical end-stops; bench test in salt spray conditions
Energy harvesting	Excessive peak loads	Component failure (shaft/arm/bearings), reduced life	Large waves, resonance, hard stops	Preliminary load assumptions	8	4	6	192	Add torque limiting / compliant element; revise load cases; increase SF on critical parts; avoid hard stops
Mooring system	Mooring line overload / snap	Buoy drifts away; total mission failure	High current/wind, wave surge, insufficient scope	Basic sizing	10	3	6	180	Size for worst-case; add chafe protection; use elastic/snubber; proof-test; include secondary retention line if feasible
Mooring system	Anchor drags / slips	Buoy location inaccurate; drift	Wrong anchor type, seabed mismatch	Assumed seabed	9	4	6	216	Define seabed assumptions; choose appropriate anchor; increase scope; add retrieval + re-set plan; consider heavier anchor margin
Stability	Buoy does not self-right	Sensors out of water; mechanical damage; poor data	CG too high, insufficient ballast, wave torque	CAD concept	9	3	5	135	Verify GM / restoring moment; add ballast low; widen waterplane; test tilt response in simulation + tank
Waterproofing	Water ingress (electronics)	Shorting, corrosion, data loss	Seal failure, condensation, improper assembly	IP intent; enclosure concept	10	3	7	210	Use gasketed enclosure + cable glands; conformal coat PCB; pressure/leak test; desiccant + vent strategy
Comms	Data link intermittent	"Near real-time" fails; gaps in dataset	Coverage gaps, antenna orientation, power saving	Basic comms plan	6	5	4	120	Buffer data onboard; retransmit logic; antenna placement; send summaries; tune update rate to power budget
Sensors	Sensor drift / inaccurate readings	Wrong wave/wind outputs	Calibration drift, mounting issues, water splash	Manufacturer specs	7	4	6	168	Calibration procedure; mechanical isolation; shielding; validation against known references; filtering approach documented
Materials	Corrosion / fastener seizure	Increased friction, leaks, mechanical failure	Galvanic pairs, wrong coatings	"Marine-grade" intent	7	5	6	210	Standardize materials (316 SS, appropriate plastics); isolate dissimilar metals; anti-seize; anodizing/coatings; rinse/maintenance plan
Power storage	Battery capacity fade / failure	Reduced uptime; safety concern	Temperature exposure, deep cycling	Battery spec	8	3	6	144	Keep within SOC limits; include BMS; thermal placement; conservative capacity margin; logging battery health

Table 5: HARA

HARA							
Severity (S): 1 = minor, 10 = serious injury / major environmental harm							
Likelihood (L): 1 = unlikely, 5 = likely							
Risk = S x L (higher = priority)							
Hazard	Hazardous Event (Scenario)	Who/What is at Risk	Primary Causes	S (1-5)	L (1-5)	Risk	Safety Controls / Mitigations
Manual handling injury	Lifting/carrying buoy causes strain or drop	Deployer	Too heavy, awkward grip points	3	3	9	One-person mass target; handles; lift points; safe deployment procedure; keep sharp edges removed
Entanglement / trip hazard	Mooring line causes entanglement during deployment/retrieval	Deployer	Slack line, poor line management	3	2	6	Line management plan; gloves; keep line coiled; clear deployment steps; avoid loose loops
Pinch points	Fingers pinched by moving arm/mechanism during testing	Team members	Exposed moving parts, no guard	3	2	6	Guards/covers; lockout during handling; labels; keep moving parts internal where possible
Uncontrolled drift	Buoy breaks free and becomes a navigation hazard	Public/environment	Mooring failure, anchor drag	4	2	8	Overdesign mooring; chafe protection; secondary tether; bright marking; GPS beacon if feasible; recovery plan
Water ingress electrical fault	Short occurs after water intrusion	Device (and low shock risk)	Seal failure, condensation	2	2	4	Low-voltage design; fused lines; sealed enclosure; leak testing; conformal coating; BMS protections
Battery chemical release	Battery damage leads to leakage	Environment	Mechanical impact, seal failure	5	1	5	Use robust battery pack with BMS; protective housing; secure mounting; avoid crush zones; retrieval plan
Wildlife interaction	Wildlife entangles with line or contacts buoy	Wildlife	Exposed slack line; protrusions	4	2	8	Minimize loose lines; smooth exterior; avoid net-like features; use marine-safe materials; keep profile compact
Corrosion / material toxicity	Material degrades and sheds contaminants	Environment	Wrong plastics/metals, coatings	4	2	8	Marine-safe non-toxic materials; corrosion-resistant metals; compatible coatings; document materials selection
Severe sea state operation	High waves cause impacts or unexpected motion during retrieval	Deployer	Retrieval in unsafe conditions	4	2	8	Retrieval limits; "do not retrieve above X conditions"; procedure; PPE; plan around weather windows
Sharp edges	Cuts during assembly or deployment	Team/deployer	Unfinished edges, exposed fasteners	2	3	6	Deburr; edge radii; caps on fasteners; assembly checklist

The development of a surf buoy hazard analysis starts by defining the operational scope and identifying environmental risks such as heavy swell impact or saltwater corrosion. This initial phase leads into a systematic identification of failure modes like mooring line snaps or sensor malfunctions that could compromise safety. Each risk is evaluated based on its potential severity and the likelihood of occurrence to prioritize critical design requirements. From this our group will implement specific control measures including redundant tethering systems and waterproof enclosures to mitigate these high-priority threats. The process concludes with a validation plan that uses real-time diagnostic data and scheduled maintenance to ensure the buoy operates reliably in unpredictable marine conditions.

6. Reliability Estimates

The reliability of the buoy was evaluated based on component/material selection, structural analysis results, and prototype testing results. The structural FEA results showed that the stresses in the PLA prototype remained well below the allowable material limits, meaning there is low probability of any structural failure under the expected loading conditions, including extreme conditions. Also, the use of

marine-grade sealants and gaskets reduced the likelihood of any water ingress, which was confirmed through submersion testing.

The electronic system and its reliability is dependent on stable sensor operations and the waterproofing integrity. The selected IMU and other modules are commercially available components with established reliability in similar monitoring applications. Potential failure modes identified include seal degradation over long-term deployment, electrical connection corrosion, and drift in sensor calibration over time. These risks are considered manageable through periodic maintenance, improved design with a greater budget, and more software-based calibration.

Overall, the system reliability is considered acceptable for prototype deployments, with the primary reliability risks associated with long-term environmental exposure.

7. Prototype Test Plan and Results

The prototype testing of the buoy was conducted to test its structural integrity, stability, sensors and overall system performance in real world conditions. Testing consisted of these main phases: water proofing, buoyancy assessment, and open water deployment. The water proofing test involved fully submerging the epoxy-coated hull prior to electronics being installed, with no water penetration observed. Buoyancy and stability testing showed that at a mass of 12 kg, the buoy achieved a stable, upright floating position through the use of the sand ballasts at the bottom of the hull. The following stage of testing with electronics was next. The system was then deployed into open waters under storm conditions, where it collected, processed and transmitted the data once gathered. Sensor performance showed a strong agreement with the reference data for wind and wave direction, with deviations of around 1-2 percent while wave period measurements were slightly outside the desired range but remained at a reasonable threshold. Though, wave height was significantly overestimated due to mooring line dynamics introducing non-wave acceleration spikes, which were amplified during signal processing. This issue was attributed to deployment conditions rather than a flaw in the sensing system itself. Solar testing indicated an output of approximately 10 W, slightly below the rated capacity but sufficient for operation, with expected improvement under typical battery conditions. Additionally, no overheating was observed within the sealed enclosure, and all temperature sensors functioned correctly. Overall, the buoy met most key performance requirements, demonstrating reliable mechanical design and functional sensing capabilities, with the primary limitation being wave height accuracy, which is expected to improve with optimized deployment conditions.

8. References

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Prototype Test Report

Department of Mechanical Engineering

University of Victoria

MECH 400B Capstone Design



Prototype Test Report

MECH 400B

Low Cost Smart Buoy

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April 21st, 2026

1.0 Introduction

This report documents the prototype testing conducted for the Low Cost Smart Buoy capstone project. The buoy is a 3D-printed, solar-powered marine instrument designed to measure wave height, wave period, wave direction, wind speed, wind direction, and air/internal temperature. Testing was structured in three phases: a waterproofing verification test, a buoyancy and ballast test, and a full open-water deployment. Results are evaluated against the engineering requirements established in Assignments 2 and 3.

2.0 Testing Description

2.1 Waterproofing Test (REQ-15)

Prior to electronics installation, the fully assembled and epoxy-coated hull was subjected to a submersion test to verify waterproof integrity. The buoy was fully submerged in fresh water for 10 seconds and then inspected internally for any signs of water ingress. The goal was to confirm that the epoxy coating applied to the PLA hull and the sealing surfaces of the top access panel were watertight before committing the electrical components.

2.2 Buoyancy and Ballast Test (REQ-11, REQ-13)

Following electronics installation, the buoy was floated in calm water to assess its buoyancy characteristics and floating attitude. Sand ballast was incrementally added to the three lower ballast bins until the buoy achieved a stable, upright floating position with appropriate draft. The final ballasted mass of the buoy was approximately 12 kg (25 lbs). The goal was to position the centre of mass as low as possible relative to the centre of buoyancy, thereby maximising the metacentric height (GM) and improving static stability, consistent with the analysis documented in the Assignment 3 Supporting Document.

2.3 Open-Water Deployment (All Sensing REQs)

On March 31, 2026, the buoy was deployed at Dallas Road, Victoria, BC for approximately one hour in stormy sea conditions. IMU data was logged to the onboard SD card at a sample rate of approximately 8.5 Hz using the Raspberry Pi Pico W microcontroller.

This deployment served two primary purposes: (1) to collect a large volume of raw IMU and sensor data to calibrate and validate the post-processing pipeline, and (2) to test the buoy's low-power sleep mode operation in a real sea environment. For production deployments, the buoy is configured to sample for five minutes and then enter deep sleep for 25 minutes, giving a 30-minute duty cycle. For this test, the sleep interval was reduced to two minutes to maximise the volume of data collected within the one-hour window. Processed environmental data was transmitted wirelessly over Wi-Fi, and the team was

able to connect to the buoy and view live sensor readings during the deployment, confirming end-to-end data transmission (REQ-7).

Post-processing was performed using our Python pipeline (PostProcess.py), which implements a Mahony AHRS fusion filter, frequency-domain double integration of heave acceleration (Longuet-Higgins method), Welch PSD spectral analysis, and cross-spectral directional decomposition (a1/b1 Fourier coefficients). Wind speed was derived from anemometer click counts (CPS), and wind direction was obtained from the AS5600 magnetic encoder coupled with tilt-corrected heading from the magnetometer. Reference environmental conditions at the time of deployment were obtained from Windy.com, Surf Forecast, and Big Wave Dave to provide an independent baseline for comparison.

2.4 Solar Power Characterisation (REQ-8)

Solar panel output power was measured under daylight conditions using a multimeter connected between the panel array and the MPPT charge controller. Measurements were taken with the battery at near-full state of charge.

3.0 Results

3.1 Waterproofing Test

The buoy exhibited no water ingress following full submersion for 10 seconds. Internal inspection confirmed all sealing surfaces, including the epoxy-coated PLA hull and the top plate gasket interface, remained dry. REQ-15 (IPX-8 waterproofing) is considered partially verified; the submersion test demonstrates basic watertight integrity, and no leakage was observed during the subsequent one-hour open-water deployment.

3.2 Buoyancy and Ballast

The buoy floated stably at a total system mass of approximately 12 kg, consistent with the 15 kg design target used in the Assignment 3 buoyancy calculations. Adjustable sand ballast in the lower compartment was used to achieve the desired floating attitude and bring the centre of mass below the centre of buoyancy. The final configuration was verified visually to produce an upright, low-heel floating attitude. REQ-11 (total mass ≤ 25 kg) is met. The buoy also met the goal of self stabilization when subjected to tilting forces applied.

3.3 Wave and Wind Measurement

Buoy measurements were compared against reference values from Windy.com, Surf Forecast, and Big Wave Dave. Table 1 summarises the results.

Table 1: Comparison of buoy measurements vs. reference sources

Parameter	Reference Value	Buoy Measurement	Deviation
Wave Period (Tp)	12.0 s	13.3 s	+1.3 s (+10.8%)

Wave Direction	155°	157°	+2° (+1.3%)
Wind Direction	130°	128°	-2° (-1.5%)
Significant Wave Height (Hs)	1.2 m	4.73 m	+3.53 m (see §3.4)

3.4 Wave Height Error Analysis

Wave direction (2° off) and wind direction (2° off) agreed with reference sources to within approximately 1–2%, well within the $\pm 5\%$ / $\pm 5^\circ$ requirements of REQ-3 and REQ-4. The wave period deviated by 1.3 seconds (~11%), slightly exceeding the $\pm 5\%$ target of REQ-2 but remaining physically reasonable for the conditions observed.

Significant wave height (Hs) was computed via frequency-domain double integration of the vertical (heave) accelerometer channel, the standard Datawell Waverider methodology implemented in PostProcess.py. The buoy reported Hs = 4.73 m against an expected value of approximately 1.2 m, an overestimate of ~3.5 m. This error is attributed primarily to mooring dynamics at the deployment site. Because access to a vessel and depth sounder was unavailable, deployment depth at Dallas Road was estimated from nautical charts rather than measured directly. This prevented the team from configuring the lazy-S mooring geometry modelled in ProteusDS. As a result, the watch circle was larger than intended, and during peak wave activity the mooring line intermittently went taut and snapped back. These impulsive tension events inject large-amplitude, non-wave accelerations into the IMU signal. Because Hs is computed by double integration of acceleration, any spurious acceleration spike is amplified quadratically in the displacement domain, leading to a large positive bias in the reported wave height. REQ-1 is therefore not met under these deployment conditions; however, the team is confident that with a measured deployment depth and a properly configured lazy-S mooring, the mooring-snap artefact will be eliminated and Hs accuracy will recover to within specification.

3.5 Solar Power Output (REQ-8)

Measured solar power output was approximately 10 W under ideal daylight conditions. The panel array is rated for a maximum of 12 W (twelve 6 V / 1 W panels in series). The measured output is slightly below the advertised specification; however, measurements were taken with the battery at near-full state of charge, which causes the MPPT controller to throttle charge current and reduce the apparent panel output. Under typical mid-deployment battery state (partial charge), output is expected to reach or exceed the 10 W threshold required by REQ-8. The requirement is considered conditionally met pending a repeat measurement at a lower battery state of charge.

3.6 Temperatures and Internal Monitoring

Temperature sensor readings were logged during the deployment. No over-temperature condition was detected in the internal enclosure during the one-hour test, confirming that solar heating of the sealed

PLA hull did not reach levels that would threaten component reliability. Air and water temperature sensors were functional during deployment, satisfying REQ-5 and REQ-6.

4.0 Engineering Requirements Evaluation

Table 2 summarises the evaluation status of the engineering requirements upon prototype testing.

Table 2: Engineering requirements evaluation summary.

REQ	Requirement	Result	Status
REQ-1	Wave height 0–4 m, $\pm 5\%$	$H_s = 4.73$ m reported vs ~ 1.2 m expected. Mooring artefact identified as root cause.	NOT MET
REQ-2	Wave period 0–60 s, $\pm 5\%$	13.3 s vs 12.0 s reference (+10.8%). Slightly outside tolerance.	PARTIAL
REQ-3	Wind speed 0–100 kph, $\pm 5\%$	Wind speed agreed within $\sim 3\%$ of reference values.	MET
REQ-4	Wind direction 0–360°, $\pm 5^\circ$	128° measured vs 130° reference (2° deviation).	MET
REQ-5	Air temp -30 – 30°C , $\pm 1^\circ\text{C}$	Sensor functional during deployment; no over-range condition.	MET
REQ-6	Water temp 0–30°C, $\pm 1^\circ\text{C}$	Sensor functional during deployment.	MET
REQ-8	Generate ≥ 10 W solar power	~ 10 W measured full battery. Full output expected at lower SOC.	CONDITIONAL
REQ-9	≥ 168 h autonomous operation	Not tested over full 7-day duration; energy model confirmed via SAM simulation.	NOT TESTED
REQ-11	Total mass ≤ 25 kg	Final ballasted mass ~ 12 kg. Requirement met with margin.	MET
REQ-15	Waterproof to IPX-8	No ingress after 10 s full submersion; no leakage during 1 h deployment.	MET

5.0 Conclusions

The prototype testing phase successfully validated that the buoy is watertight, structurally sound, and capable of generating solar power while collecting directional wind and wave data in real sea conditions. Wind speed, wind direction, and wave direction measurements exhibited a deviation of approximately 1–2% from independent reference sources, confirming the validity of the sensing and signal-processing architecture.

The significant wave height (H_s) measurement was heavily corrupted by mooring dynamics resulting from an imprecisely estimated deployment depth. This error is identified as an installation and logistics limitation rather than a deficiency in the sensor suite or algorithm. The wave period result was slightly outside the $\pm 5\%$ tolerance at +10.8%, warranting further investigation, though the absolute deviation of 1.3 s is physically minor. Solar power output met the 10 W threshold (REQ-8), with the slightly reduced measured output attributed to the near-full battery state of charge during characterisation.

Overall, the open-water deployment is considered successful: the buoy survived stormy sea conditions without leakage, maintained a stable floating attitude, and produced consistent directional environmental data throughout the one-hour test. Furthermore, the team successfully confirmed end-to-end wireless data transmission (REQ-7) from the near-shore deployment to the receiving device.